Rubric historical essay

Criterion	Unsatisfactory	Satisfactory	Good	Excellent
Question and thesis	No clear question or thesis.	Clear question and a thesis that guides the essay.	Thesis is nuanced and well defined.	Thesis is original and sharp, and carries the whole essay.
Historical accuracy	Factual errors about events, actors or dates.	Facts correct in broad terms.	Facts correct and placed in the right context.	Precise and well documented, including details.
Use of sources	Primary sources without a reference, or too little literature.	Primary and secondary sources recognisably used.	Sources used critically, with attention to perspective and context.	Sources firmly anchored and critically weighed against each other.
Historiography and counter-arguments	No other positions discussed.	Another position mentioned.	Different historiographical positions discussed and rebutted.	Debate carefully presented and own position convincingly argued.
Historical thinking	The past is judged by present-day norms without acknowledging this.	Distinction between then and now largely made.	Conscious distinction between historical context and present-day judgement.	Also explicit reflection on the author's own standpoint.
Structure and language	Disorganised or many errors.	Logical structure, some errors.	Clear paragraphs and a conclusion that follows from the argument.	Error-free, persuasive and highly readable.